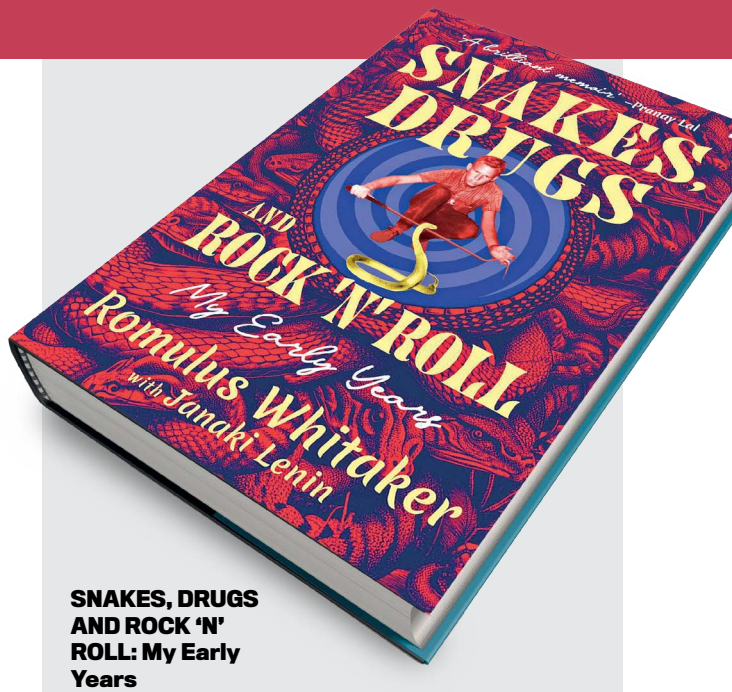



**SNAKES, DRUGS AND ROCK 'N' ROLL: My Early Years**
*by Romulus Whitaker with Janaki Lenin*
HARPERCOLLINS
**₹699; 400** pages

# R

Romulus Whitaker has too many answers. The question: Any favourite snake species? "There's lots and lots of favourites," he says. Then offers up two: the eastern diamondback rattlesnake and the indigo snake. These and others star prominently in *Snakes, Drugs and Rock 'n' Roll: My Early Years* (HarperCollins), an account of Whitaker's wild and wondrous life in India and the US, co-written with his wife, the writer and filmmaker Janaki Lenin.

Whitaker, 80, often known affectionately as the 'Snakeman of India', is among the country's best-known conservationists. He established the Madras Snake Park, the Madras Crocodile Bank Trust and has worked extensively on India's rainforests. In 2018, he received the Padma Shri.

*Snakes...* is a chatty, delightful, anecdote-driven book of a richly lived life—the first of three planned volumes—and details Whitaker's childhood and adolescence.

Whitaker was born in the US in 1943 and raised by a single mother in New York state, before they relocated to Bombay when she married an Indian, Rama Chattopadhyay, son of Harindranath and Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay. "I felt like I'd landed on another planet," he writes. "My new home and country were far more exciting than anything I had experienced in the States in my eight-year existence."

The wildlife bug had already taken root in America. In India, it blossomed further. Whitaker hung out with fishermen in sleepy Juhu, shot sparrows in Worli, kept a pet snake and delighted in the pet shops of Crawford Market. He went to boarding school in Kodaikanal where he embraced the fauna of the Western Ghats.

# WHEN GREEN SEES RED

Ecologist **Madhav Gadgil**'s seventh book, *A Walk Up the Hill* is a chronicle of his life and times in a nation at odds with its environment

For those enamoured with treks in the Western Ghats and Instagram-worthy landscapes, Madhav Gadgil's comprehensive memoir is a necessary reality check. As a prominent ecologist who spearheaded a government task force for sustainable development of this ecosystem, he grapples with optimism and despair in his seventh book. Against the backdrop of a political climate where environmental regulations have become mere formalities, *A Walk Up the Hill: Living with People and Nature* offers a poignant and reflective journey.

Gadgil was guided towards a career in ecology through a love for nature inherited from his father Dhananjay Ramchandra Gadgil, a distinguished economist and policymaker, who was honoured with a postage stamp. His formative years were shaped by outdoor explorations and the profound influence of his father's friend, the ornithologist Sálim Ali. Living next door to the pioneering sociologist and anthropologist Irawati Karve enriched his upbringing. When he was nine, his parents granted him a month away from school to accompany Karve in Kodagu. This experience of observing her work with tribal communities proved fundamental in shaping his approach to field-oriented research despite limited funding.

**As a prominent ecologist, Gadgil grapples with optimism and despair in his book**

Reflecting on this intimate connection with rural India, Gadgil acknowledges how it cultivated a unique environmental consciousness distinct from that of "urban nature lovers". In stark contrast, he does not perceive rural people as the "principal enemies of India's nature". Throughout his memoir, his recommendations target regressive, colonial-minded policies that have marginalised people from ecological decision-making. Drawing inspiration from the 19th-century Dalit social reformer Jyotirao Phule,

